

The loud silence of echo*

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1. Introduction

Echo questions, or *echos* for short, ask the addressee to clarify the utterance they just produced by repeating (some part of) it. Echos can be used to convey that the speaker did not hear (part of) what was said or to signal surprise, outrage, etc. triggered by what was said—I will mostly set this distinction aside. We can furthermore distinguish between *polar echos* (asking if their prejacent matches the antecedent utterance) and *wh-echos* (asking a wh-question about some part of the antecedent utterance). Finally, we can have echos to antecedent utterances of different types. Thus, (1) illustrates polar and wh-echos in English to assertions, polar questions (PolQs), wh-questions (wh-Qs), and directives.¹

- (1) a. A: I gave you a book.
B: {You gave me a book? / You gave me what? / What did you give me?}
- b. A: Did you give me a book?
B: {Did I give you a book? / Did I give you what?}
- c. A: What did you give me?
B: {What did I give you? / What did I what?}
- d. A: Give me a book.
B: {Give you a book? / Give you what?}

In English, echos tend to use non-neutral forms (e.g., rising declaratives and imperatives, wh-in-situ questions), but these forms typically still have non-echo uses, and in general, the internal structure of English echos is not always clear from their form. While it is commonly assumed that prosody can distinguish echo vs. non-echo questions,² Biezma et al.

*Many thanks to the audiences at NELS 56 and the colloquium series at Ben-Gurion University. Sound files for selected examples from this paper can be found at <https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/UXKCN>. When a sound file is available, its name is given after the example in parentheses.

¹Echos to exclamations exist, as well, but I will set those aside completely in this paper.

²Although I think this claim usually concerns wh-Qs specifically. I have not seen much on the prosody of polar echos, but in English, they all seem to involve the rising tune at least—I come back to this in section 6.

(2021) claim that neither word order, nor prosody reliably distinguish echo vs. non-echo interpretations of wh-Qs in English. However, they only look at wh-echos to assertions and, furthermore, they do, in fact, find prosodic differences between echo and non-echo wh-Qs, but they deem them non-categorical based on undisclosed criteria. They then conclude that the difference between echo vs. non-echo questions in English is not their compositional semantic representation, but “their position in the discourse”, where echos are “questions about what exactly the proposal to be evaluated is”. I will not rehash the specifics of their formal proposal in this paper. Again, in their analysis, they only focus on wh-echos to assertions, but claim that this analysis can be extended to all other cases, although I don’t necessarily understand the full details of how exactly to do so.

Other languages exhibit form differences between echo and non-echo questions that ostensibly necessitate distinct compositional representations. Thus, Sudo (2007) shows that Japanese echo vs. non-echo questions use different particles and proposes that the particle that only appears in echo questions realizes a special ECHO complementizer.

In this paper, I will look at morphosyntactic and prosodic properties of different types of echos in Russian. I will show that while there doesn’t seem to be a systematic overt way to realize any kind of ECHO operator in Russian (segmental or suprasegmental), we have evidence that echos in Russian systematically involve embedding under a silent ECHO predicate, which is a speech report predicate anaphoric to the antecedent utterance.³

This paper is organized as follows. Section 2 provides an overview of non-echo questions in Russian. Section 3 shows that polar echos to questions in Russian clearly involve embedding. Section 4 then argues that echos to assertions in Russian, too, involve embedding, even though the evidence is less direct. Section 5 provides further evidence that echos in Russian involve embedding across the board by looking at echos to imperatives. Section 6 wraps up by discussing the possibility that there might still exist strategies that achieve echo-like interpretation effects without any ECHO predicate or operator.

2. Non-echo questions in Russian

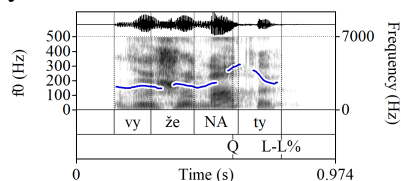
Russian famously has two matrix PolQ forms, as illustrated in (2). One is the more neutral *declarative string questions* (DSQs), which are comprised of the same segmental string as declarative assertions, but carry a special prosodic peak on the locus of prosodic focus marking that is robustly distinct in production and perception from focus marking in assertions (see, e.g., Meyer and Mleinek 2006). Following Esipova 2024, I will call this peak *the Q-Peak* and will annotate it as Q. The other—more marked—PolQ form is *li* PolQs (li-Qs), in which the semantically focused constituent (or some part of it) is fronted, and the *li* particle is cliticized onto it. Non-echo li-Qs carry assertion-like focus marking (for which I will use ToBI-like annotation, typically (L+)H*⁴) on the fronted constituent and cannot have the Q-Peak. Both PolQ forms have a falling boundary contour.

³This proposal seemingly aligns in spirit with some converging claims in the ongoing work by Trinh, Fox, and Bassi, which was also presented at NELS 56, but some of the details appear to differ.

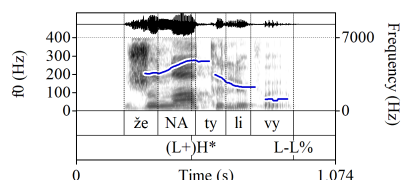
⁴More generally, I will be using ToBI-like annotation for Russian intonation without assuming that Russian has the exact same intonational system as English.

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- (2) a. Vy žena_Qty_{L-L%}? (DSQ; ‘you-married-q’)
you married⁵



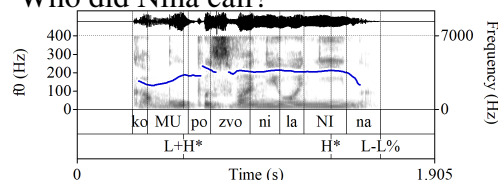
- b. Žena_(L+)H*ty li vy_{L-L%}? (li-Q; ‘married-li-you-hat’)
married LI you



‘Are you married?’ (both (a) and (b) can be unbiased info-seeking non-echo PolQs)

Wh-Qs in Russian are formed by fronting the wh-phrase (or some part of it), as illustrated in (3).⁶ The wh-item bears assertion-like focus marking and cannot bear the Q-Peak, and the boundary contour is a falling one, i.e., they have the same prosody as li-Qs.

- (3) Komu_{L+H*} pozvonila Nina_{L-L%}? (‘who-called-nina-hat’)
who.DAT called Nina.NOM
‘Who did Nina call?’



Li-Qs and wh-Qs are embeddable while DSQs are not:

- (4) On sprosil {ženat_(L+)H* li ja_{L-L%} / *ja ženat_{Q L-L%} / kto_(L+)H* ženat_{L-L%}}.
he asked {married LI I / *I married / who married}
‘He asked if I am married / who is married.’

Furthermore, DSQs always expect a response (e.g., they cannot be conjectural questions), but li-Qs and wh-Qs do not (Esipova and Korotkova 2023). Besides, the Q-Peak can also be used with imperatives, but only to yield “invested requests”, not “disinterested suggestions” (Esipova 2024). Thus, while the specifics do not matter for this paper, I will assume, for concreteness, that Russian *li*- and *wh*-clauses are interrogatives denoting sets of pos-

⁵I use simplified glosses across the board for Russian examples, only indicating morphosyntactic information such as case when it is relevant for the point being made and/or to avoid ambiguity.

⁶There can be additional word order permutations in different types of questions, like subject–verb inversion, which we see in (3). These are irrelevant for the purposes of this paper and will be ignored.

sible answers. In a matrix context, they combine with a regular, default Question force operator, which, among other things, projects common grounds based on the alternatives in the denotation of the interrogative. In contrast, the Q-Peak realizes a special, “intrusive” Question force operator (in addition to marking focus, which signals the parent question of the PolQ), which combines with singleton sets (declarative and imperative clauses) and projects commitments for the addressee based on the sentence radical and its complement.⁷

With this background in place, let us start looking at echos in Russian.

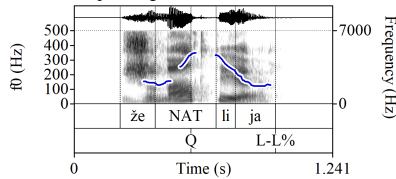
3. Polar echos to questions in Russian

In English, wh-echos to questions, like those in (1b–c), are at least visibly questions about questions, but it is less obviously so for polar echos, especially polar echos to PolQs, as these can fully match their antecedents in form, with auxiliary inversion and the rising tune:

- (5) A: Are you ma_L*ried_{H-H%}?
B: Am I ma_L*ried_{H-H%}? (≈ ‘Did you just ask me if I am married?’)

I’ll come back to English in section 6, but in Russian, polar echos to questions are very clearly DSQs embedding li-Qs (if the antecedent is a PolQ) or wh-Qs (if the antecedent is a wh-Q). Thus, as shown in (6B), in polar echos to PolQs, the segmental string is necessarily that of a li-Q (regardless of if the antecedent is a DSQ or a li-Q), but there is also necessarily a Q-Peak there. The DSQ in (6B’’) is just bad in this context. The regular Q-Peak-less li-Q in (6B’) can only be understood as a conjectural question along the lines of ‘Hm... Good question. Am I married indeed?’. Neither can have the intended echo interpretation.

- (6) A: {Vy žena_Qty_{L-L%}? / Žena_(L+)H*ty li vy_{L-L%}?} (= (2))
{you married / married LI you}
‘Are you married?’
B: Ženat_Q li ja_{L-L%}? (‘married-q-li-i’)
married LI I
≈ ‘Did you just ask me if I am married?’ (can only be an echo to a PolQ)

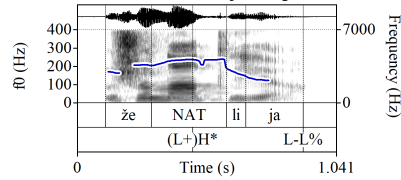


- B': #Ženat_(L+)H* li ja_{L-L%}? (‘married-li-i-hat’)
married LI I

⁷Pace Farkas 2022, 2024, where the default discourse effects of all questions involve projecting commitments for the addressee.

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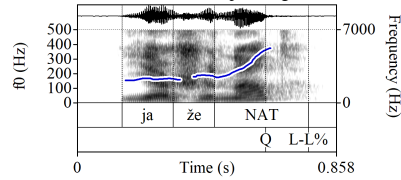
Intended: ≈‘Did you just ask me if I am married?’



B'': #Ja ženat_Q L-L%? ('i-married-q')

I married

Intended: ≈‘Did you just ask me if I am married?’



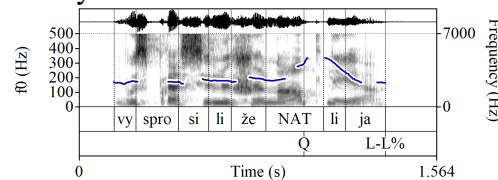
Note also that the Q-Peak, as usual, goes on the locus of prosodic focus marking. In (6B), that's the entire embedded *li*-Q (≈‘Did you just ask me [if I am married]_F?’). If, for instance, the speaker wasn't sure if the antecedent question was about them, it would have been placed on *ja* ('I') (≈‘Did you just ask me if [I]_F am married?’).

In other words, (6B) is ostensibly a DSQ embedding a *li*-Q, suggesting a compositional structure as in (7), where the ECHO predicate is a silent speech report predicate anaphoric to the antecedent utterance.⁸

- (7) [Q-PEAK [ECHO [married [*li* [I <married>]]]]]
 ≈‘Please address the issue of whether the utterance you just produced asks whether I am married.’

This compositional structure is similar to the English paraphrase in (6B) or indeed its Russian counterpart in (8), which has the same prosodic contour as (6B).

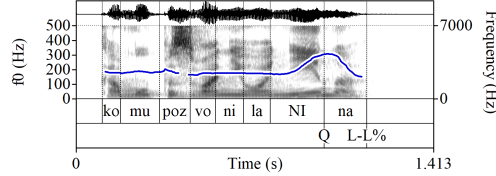
- (8) Vy sprosili ženat_Q li ja_{L-L%}? ('you-asked-married-q-li-i')
 you asked married LI I
 ‘Did you ask if I am married?’



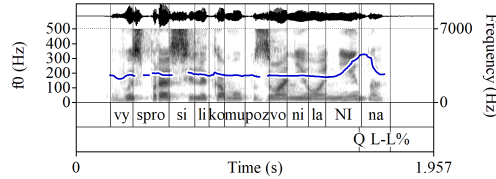
Polar echos to wh-Qs must also have the Q-Peak (which, remember, wh-Qs themselves cannot have, just like *li*-Qs), as shown in (9B), again suggesting the structure in (10) with a DSQ embedding a wh-Q, similar to the DSQ with an overt speech report predicate in (9B').

⁸I don't use more specific labels like ASK or ASSERT, because the idea is that these details are retrieved anaphorically based on the force of the antecedent utterance.

- (9) A: Komu_{L+H}* pozvonila Nina_{L-L}%? (= (3))
 who.DAT called Nina.NOM
 ‘Who did Nina call?’
- B: Komu pozvonila Ni_Qna_{L-L}%? (‘who-called-nina-q’)
 who.DAT called Nina.NOM
 (only echo: ≈‘Did you just ask me who Nina called?’)



- B': Vy sprosili komu pozvonila Ni_Qna_{L-L}%?
 you asked who.DAT called Nina.NOM
 (‘you-asked-who-called-nina-q’)
 ‘Did you ask who Nina called?’



- (10) [Q-PEAK [ECHO [who.DAT [Nina called <who.DAT>]]]]
 ≈‘Please address the issue of whether the utterance you just produced asks who Nina called.’

Now that we have established that polar echos to questions in Russian very clearly involve embedding, let us see if there is any evidence that echos to assertions do.

4. Echos to assertions in Russian

4.1 Polar echos to assertions in Russian

Neutral polar echos to assertions in Russian are just DSQs,⁹ but there appears to be a pressure for some speakers (myself included) to signal that these DSQs are echos by producing the corresponding wh-echo first—at least in echos with a sentence-level Q-Peak, as indicated by the question mark on the parentheses around the wh-echo (cf. (11B'), with narrow focus, where I don't feel this pressure to the same extent).

- (11) A: Ljudmila pozvonila Nine.
 Lyudmila.NOM called Nina.DAT

⁹This is contrary to my claim in Esipova 2024 that only rising declaratives can be used as echos to assertions in Russian. I'll come back to rising declaratives as echos in section 6, but the reason why I was confused was because of this pressure to signal that DSQs like (11B) are echos by producing a wh-echo first.

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‘Lyudmila called Nina.’

B: ?(Čto-čto_L*_{H-H%}?) Ljudmila pozvonila NiQne_{L-L%}?
 ?(what-what) Lyudmila.NOM called Nina.DAT
 (‘what-what-I-called-n-q’)
 ‘(What?) [Lyudmila called Nina]_F?’

B’: (Kto_L*_{H-H%}?) LjudmiQla (pozvonila Nine)_{L-L%}?
 (who.NOM called Nina.DAT) Lyudmila.NOM (called Nina.DAT)
 (‘who-rise-called-n-I-q-called-n’)
 ‘(Who called Nina?) [Lyudmila]_F called Nina?’

These facts are compatible with the compositional structure in (12), although they don’t immediately necessitate it.

- (12) [Q-PEAK [ECHO [Lyudmila.NOM called Nina.DAT]]]
 ≈‘Please address the issue of whether the utterance you just produced asserts that Lyudmila called Nina.’

However, there is still indirect evidence that Russian polar echos to assertions involve embedding coming from the fact that li-Qs cannot be used as such echos. So far we have only seen DSQs as polar echos (recall that the *li*-clause in (6B) is a li-Q embedded in a DSQ). But can li-Qs be used as polar echos? If li-Qs were to be used as echos to assertions and if echos to assertions do, in fact, have a structure with embedding, then hypothetical li-Q echos would involve the following structure:

- (13) [XP_F [*li* [ECHO [...<XP_F>...]]]]

Now, we wouldn’t expect li-Qs to be able to be echos when the whole complement of ECHO is in focus, because matrix li-Qs cannot have sentence-level focus. However, attempts to have li-Q echos with narrower loci of uncertainty are still bad. Thus, the li-Q in (14B) can be at best interpreted as a challenging ≈‘Was it really [Lyudmila]_F that Nina called?’ question (but then we would probably have a different type of accent on the fronted constituent than what we typically have in non-challenging li-Qs), but it cannot be an echo question.

- (14) A: Nina pozvonila Ljudmile.
 Nina.NOM called Lyudmila.DAT
 ‘Nina called Lyudmila.’
- B: (Komu_L*_{H-H%}?) #Ljudmi_{L+H*}le li pozvonila
 (who.DAT called Nina.NOM) #Lyudmila.DAT LI called
 Nina_{L-L%}? (‘who-rise-called-n-I-q-called-n’)
 Nina.NOM
 Intended: ‘(Who [did you just say] Nina called?) [Did you just say that] Nina called [Lyudmila]_F?’

There are at least two potential considerations here that can help us explain why li-Qs cannot be echos, which are not mutually exclusive. First, li-Qs are in general quite marked; among other things, as mentioned before, they are less intrusive than DSQs and thus often sound non-urgent, which might make them less pragmatically appropriate when the resolution of the issue they raise is necessary for continuing the discourse. However, the impossibility of li-Qs as echos is categorical, so it's probably not purely pragmatic.

Now note that under the analysis proposed here, the hypothetical li-Q echo in (14B) would need to have the structure in (15).

- (15) [Lyudmila.DAT [*li* [ECHO [called Nina.NOM <Lyudmila.DAT>]]]]
 ≈ 'Is Lyudmila the *x* s.t. the utterance you just produced asserts that Nina called *x*?'

However, this kind of extraction seems bad in general, as shown in (16a), especially since one can simply do the DSQ in (16b) instead, which doesn't involve extraction.

- (16) a. *Ljudmile li ty skazal (čto) pozvonila Nina?
 Lyudmila.DAT LI you said (that) called Nina.NOM
 Intended: 'Did you say that Nina called [Lyudmila]_F?'
 b. Ty skazal (čto) Nina pozvonila LjudmiQ_{le_{L-L}%}?
 you said (that) Nina.NOM called Lyudmila.DAT
 'Did you say that Nina called [Lyudmila]_F?'

Thus, if echos to assertions still involve structures with embedding like (12), we can attribute the categorical unavailability of li-Q echos to the general unavailability of li-Qs like (16a) that involve extracting the focused constituent from an embedded clause. In other words, this is indirect evidence that even in echos to assertions we still have structures with embedding under the ECHO predicate.

4.2 Wh-echos to assertions in Russian

I will now briefly discuss wh-echos to assertions in Russian. They do not provide any further evidence for a structure with embedding, but my goal here is to show that while wh-echos in Russian have a very distinct form profile, none of the components of this profile are specific to echos and, thus, none of them realize the ECHO predicate.

Unlike in English, we typically do front wh-phrases in wh-echos in Russian, just like in non-echo wh-questions. However, wh-echos differ from non-echo wh-Qs in Russian prosodically. The latter have a "hat" contour, as shown in (3), while the former have the Russian equivalent of the rising tune,¹⁰ as shown in (17).

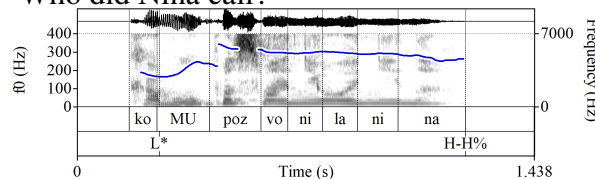
- (17) A: Nina pozvonila Ljudmile.
 Nina.NOM called Lyudmila.DAT

¹⁰It is actually a rise into a high plateau in Russian, unlike in English, but I still annotate it as L* H-H%.

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‘Nina called Lyudmila.’

- B: Komu_L* pozvonila Nina_{H-H%}?¹¹ (‘who-rise-called-nina’)
 who.DAT called Nina.NOM
 ‘Who did Nina call?’



This tune is not specific to echos, though. For instance, rising declaratives do exist in Russian, as discussed further in section 6, as well, and they don’t have to be echos. Besides, the same rising tune is used in wh-Qs about the antecedent utterance with overt speech report predicates like (21) below, so it definitely cannot be a realization of the ECHO predicate.

We also often see reduplication of the wh-item in wh-echos in Russian, as shown before in (11B) and below in (18), although I think there might be various constraints on this reduplication pertaining to the antecedent, and there also seems to be a preference for eliding the rest of the question when the wh-item is reduplicated.

- (18) A: Nina pozvonila Ljudmile.
 Nina.NOM called Lyudmila.DAT
 ‘Nina called Lyudmila.’
 B: Komu-komu_L* H-H%? (‘who-who’)
 who.DAT-who.DAT
 ‘Who [did Nina call]?’

Once again, I believe this reduplication is a subcase of the larger phenomenon of reduplication in certain types of responses (in a broad sense, not necessarily to a question), some of which are illustrated in (19). In other words, this reduplication is not a realization of the ECHO predicate either, but instead contributes some broad meaning related to the host utterance being a response, which, when combined with whatever contribution the rising tune makes and the semantics of a wh-interrogative, points to an echo interpretation in cases like (18), but has a different effect in all these other cases in (19).

¹¹While this prosody in wh-Qs is very strongly associated with echo interpretations, the same form can also be used to mean ≈‘Who did Nina call again?’, i.e., to ask a question that has been settled before to indicate that you need a reminder of how it was settled. Such questions seem to be at least cousins of echo questions. While they don’t point back to the immediate antecedent utterance, they are still ostensibly anaphoric, as indicated by both the English use of *again*, whose presupposition is often assumed to be anaphoric, as well as the possible use of *tam* (lit. ‘there’, i.e., a distal demonstrative) in Russian questions of this type, the latter quite clearly indicating that there is an antecedent, but it is remote. Thus, it is possible that at least in Russian, these questions also involve a structure with embedding, along the lines of ≈‘Who [did we previously establish] Nina called?’, with the main difference between these and echo questions being the closeness/remoteness of the antecedent.

- (19) a. A: Kto pozvonil Ljudmila?
 who.NOM called Lyudmila.DAT
 ‘Who called Ljudmila?’
 B: Kto-kto! Nina!
 who.NOM-who.NOM Nina.NOM
 ≈‘Nina [and you’re stupid for asking this question].’ (a mocking repetition of the antecedent question; no rising tune)
- b. A: Vam čto-nibud’ nužno?
 you.DAT something.NOM needed
 ‘Do you need anything?’
 B: Net-net, spasibo.
 no-no thanks
 ≈‘No, thanks.’ (a polite negative response; no rising tune)
- c. *Context: someone knocks on the door.*
- (i) Da-da
 yes-yes
 ≈‘Yes?’ (a response to someone trying to get your attention signaling that they have it; can have the rising tune, but it’s not the only option)
- (ii) Sejčas-sejčas!
 now-now
 ≈‘Just a second!’ (a response indicating that you will address something that requires your attention in a bit; no rising tune)

The bottom line is that while wh-echos in Russian have a distinct form profile, no individual component of this profile is specific to echos and, thus, cannot be realizing the ECHO predicate. Despite that, it makes sense to assume a uniform structure for polar and wh-echos, with, for instance, the wh-echo in (17B) having the compositional structure in (20).

- (20) [who.DAT [ECHO [called Nina.NOM <who.DAT>]]]
 ≈‘What x is s.t. the utterance you just produced asserts that Nina called x ?’

Importantly, unlike with li-Qs, such extraction is grammatical in counterparts with overt speech report predicates, at least when there is no overt complementizer (in li-Qs, the absence or presence of an overt complementizer makes no difference):

- (21) Komu_L* ty skazal (?čto) pozvonila Nina_{H-H%}?
 who.DAT you said (?that) called Nina.NOM
 ‘Who did you say (that) Nina called?’

Besides the uniform approach being more economical here, there is further evidence for this structure for both polar and wh-echos from echos to imperatives, which I turn to next.

5. Echos to imperatives in Russian

While we cannot necessarily conclude much about the morphosyntax of echos to imperatives in English, since English doesn't have a dedicated imperative verb form, in Russian, echos to imperatives cannot use imperative forms, but have to use infinitives instead. This is true for both polar and wh-echos, as shown in (22).

- (22) A: $\text{Daj}_{(L+)_H^*} \text{ mne } \text{kni}_{H^*} \text{gu}_{L-L\%}$. ('give-me-book')
 give.IMP me.DAT book.ACC
 'Give me a/the book.'
- B: $\{\text{Dat}' / * \text{Daj}\} \text{ tebe } \text{kni}_{Q\text{gu}_{L-L\%}} ?$ ('give-you-book-q')
 $\{\text{give.INF} / * \text{give.IMP}\} \text{ you.DAT book.ACC}$
 'Give you a/the book?'
- B': $\check{\text{Cto}}_{L^*} \text{ tebe } \{\text{dat}' / * \text{daj}\}_{H-H\%} ?$ ('what-rise-you-give')
 what.ACC you.DAT $\{\text{give.INF} / * \text{give.IMP}\}$
 'Give you what?'

Note that imperative forms cannot be embedded under speech report predicates in Russian, and to obtain an embedded directive interpretation, one must use infinitives instead:

- (23) On skazal $\{\text{dat}' / * \text{daj}\} \text{ emu } \text{kni}\check{\text{g}}\text{u}$.
 he said $\{\text{give.INF} / * \text{give.IMP}\} \text{ him.DAT book.ACC}$
 'He said give him a/the book.'

One could try to attribute the unacceptability of imperative forms in (22B) and (23) to phi-feature mismatch, but Russian imperative forms can be used elsewhere, for instance, in counterfactuals like (24), where the purported feature mismatch isn't an issue.

- (24) $\text{Pridi } \{\text{ja} / \text{oni}\} \text{ poran'she, my by vs}\check{\text{e}} \text{ uspel}.$
 come.IMP.T/SG $\{\text{I} / \text{they}\} \text{ earlier we SUBJ all had.time.to.do}$
 'Had I/they come earlier, we would have had time to do everything.'

So even if the problem with embedded imperatives in (23) is due to feature mismatch, it emerges specifically in the context of embedding under a speech report predicate, and since we already established the need of an embedding ECHO predicate in some types of echos in Russian, we might as well attribute the facts in (22) to the presence of this predicate in echos to imperatives, as well. In other words, the structure of the echos in (22B) is as in (25) and is similar to the English paraphrases in (22B) or their Russian counterparts in (26).

- (25) a. $[\text{Q-PEAK} [\text{ECHO} [\text{give.INF you.DAT book.ACC}]]]$
 ≈ 'Please address the issue of whether the utterance you just produced is a directive to give you a/the book.'

- b. [what.ACC [ECHO [you.DAT give.INF <what.ACC>]]]
 ≈‘What x is s.t. the utterance you just produced is a directive to give you x ?’
- (26) a. Ty skazal dat’ tebe kni_Qgu_{L-L}%?
 you.NOM said give.INF you.DAT book.ACC
 (‘you-said-give-you-book-q’)
 ‘Did you tell [me] to give you a/the book?’
- b. Čto_L* ty skazal tebe dat’_{H-H}%?
 what.ACC you.NOM said you.DAT give.INF
 (‘what-rise-you-said-you-give’)
 ‘What did you tell [me] to give you?’

Note also that polar echos to imperatives, like in (22B), once again have the Q-Peak, but it’s not just a Q-Peak slapped directly onto a directive. Q-Peak-marked directives do exist in Russian; in fact, even Q-Peak-marked imperatives exist—but they are used as friendly requests (Esipova 2024) and cannot have echo interpretations (cf. English rising imperatives that can have both interpretations without changes to the verb form). This clearly indicates that polar echos to imperatives in Russian are DSQs that embed infinitives.

6. Echo effects without ECHO?

Before I wrap up, let me add a note on whether there exist strategies of achieving echo-like interpretations that do not involve any kind of ECHO predicate or operator.

In English, polar echos appear to be formed by simply repeating the antecedent utterance with the rising tune (of course, with appropriate changes to indexicals, etc.). It is unclear to me if such polar echos involve any kind of embedding structure or any kind of ECHO operator whatsoever. Rudin (2018), Rudin and Rudin (2022) maintain that the English rising tune simply removes the speaker’s commitment to their utterance. Thus, for instance, a declarative assertion with the sentence radical denoting a proposition p adds a commitment to p for the speaker and puts the issue $\{p\}$ on the Table; adding the rising tune then simply removes the commitment part. It might be possible then to derive the echo effects in rising declaratives used as polar echos as simply coming from the fact that $\{p\}$ is already on the Table. Whether this insight is on the right track, and if so, how exactly it should be implemented and whether it is generalizeable to all other cases of polar echos seemingly formed via the rising tune only remains to be seen, however. It is also unclear if and how any of this applies to wh-echos.

Turning to Russian then, so far we have seen that Russian polar echos are systematically DSQs, which embed declaratives, li-Qs, wh-Qs, and infinitives—depending on the nature of the antecedent utterance. However, Russian does also have rising declaratives, although these are used much less frequently than in English. Example (27) shows that both rising declaratives and DSQs with a sentence-level Q-Peak can be used as what we call *explanation-seeking questions* in Esipova and Romero 2023, which are evidentially biased questions that ask if the prejacent p is the explanation for some contextual evidence.

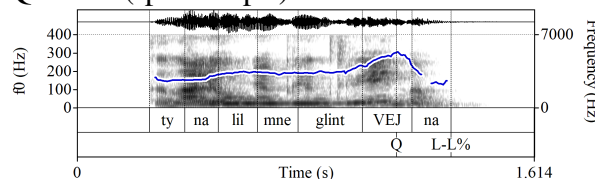
The loud silence of echo

However, rising declaratives seemingly tend to sound more surprised in Russian than DSQs with a sentence-level Q-Peak.

- (27) *Context: We're having dinner. I stepped away for a minute and come back to a glass of mulled wine next to my plate. I am asking what the explanation for this is:*

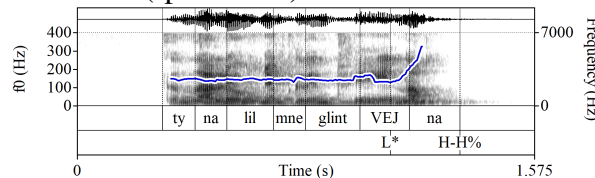
Ty nalil mne glintvejna?
you.NOM poured me.DAT mulled-wine.GEN

- a. Q L-L% ('pour-expl')



'[What is the explanation for this?] Did you pour me mulled wine?'

- b. L* H-H% ('pour-rise')



'[What is the explanation for this?] You poured me mulled wine?'

While the judgements are a bit tentative and preliminary, it seems like rising declaratives can also be used as polar echos to assertions in Russian, but they sound more incredulous rather than genuinely confused about the antecedent ((L+)H* H-H% is also possible with rising declaratives in Russian, and these sound extra incredulous):

- (28) A: Ljudmila pozvonila Nine.
Lyudmila.NOM called Nina.DAT
'Lyudmila called Nina.'
- B: (Čto-čto_{L*} H-H%?) Ljudmila pozvonila Ni_{L*}ne_{H-H%}?
(what-what) Lyudmila.NOM called Nina.DAT
(‘what-what-I-called-n-rise’)
(‘What?) [Lyudmila called Nina]_F?’
- B': (Kto_{L*} pozvonil Nine_{H-H%}?) Ljudmi_{L*}la (pozvonila Nine)_{H-H%}?
(who.NOM called Nina.DAT) Lyudmila.NOM (called Nina.DAT)
(‘who-rise-called-n-I-rise-called-n’)
(‘Who called Nina?) [Lyudmila]_F called Nina?’

Like in English, there is no evidence that echo rising declaratives like in (28B) are compositionally distinct from non-echo rising declaratives like in (27b), and we might also be able to derive the echo effects contextually, based on what is already on the Table. However, it is

unclear if the rising tune in Russian has the same semantics as in English. For one thing, I don't think it can be used in other types of polar echos in Russian, unlike what we observe in English. Also, whatever analysis we have for the rising tune and echo uses of rising declaratives in Russian needs to be compatible with the obligatory use of the rising tune in wh-echos in Russian. Finally, the apparent surprise effect in Russian rising declaratives (which does not, by the way, arise in wh-echos) needs to be dealt with, as well.

The bottom line is that echo questions in Russian systematically involve embedding under an ECHO predicate. While this predicate is ostensibly silent in Russian, its presence is nonetheless felt in the compositional structure across multiple types of echos. It is possible, however, that pragmatic strategies of achieving echo-like interpretations, which do not involve any kind of ECHO predicate or operator at all, do still exist in other languages and perhaps even in Russian. Establishing a full taxonomy of echo strategies cross-linguistically would thus be a worthy direction for future research.

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